



Queen Elizabeth's pelican brooch

△ Enamel pelican, Elizabeth I's signature emblem

While much is known about the symbolism of Queen

Elizabeth I's pelican brooch, information on the piece itself is scant. The last known image of it is the *Pelican Portrait of Queen Elizabeth I*, attributed to artist Nicholas Hilliard. The painting was produced around halfway through Elizabeth's reign, when she was around 40 years old, a time when religious iconography became more important to her public portrayal. In the painting, the brooch is fastened to Elizabeth's richly adorned dress and depicts a pelican with a bloodied breast and her young around her. The enamel pelican hangs from a square-cut diamond set in gold and rests atop a square-cut ruby.

Elizabeth is known to have favoured two symbols – the phoenix and the pelican. While the former signified her endurance



Van Cleef & Arpels clip featuring the pelican motif

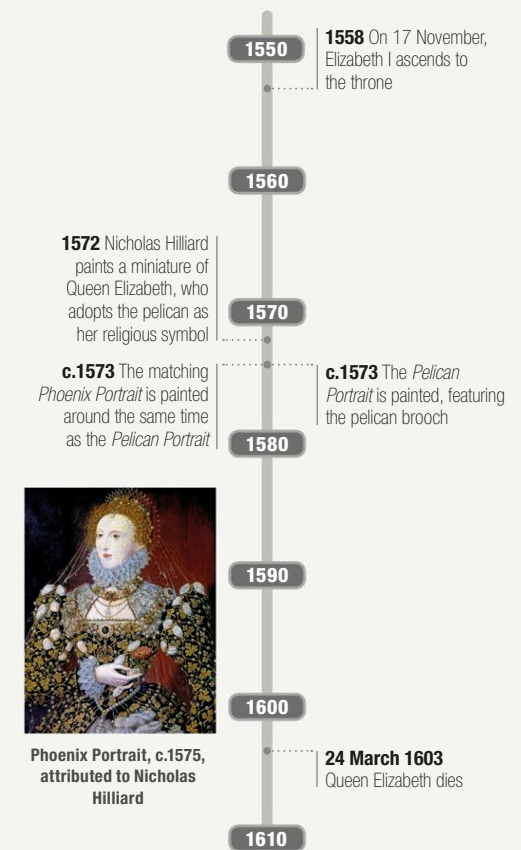
and her long reign, the pelican symbolized her devotion to her subjects. In ancient legend, it was thought that a mother pelican, in times of scarcity, will peck at her body in order to feed her young with her own blood, perhaps based on the

way pelicans press their bills against their breasts to fully empty food from their throat pouches. This legend, which predates Christianity, was adopted by early Christians to represent Christ's sacrifice and the gift of his body and blood in the Eucharist – he was sometimes referred to as "the Pelican".

Elizabeth adopted the symbol, wishing to be seen as the selfless mother of her people, placing her subjects' needs before her own. Her courtiers, aware of her personal adoption of these emblems, gave her gifts of pelican and phoenix jewellery, such as appear in this portrait and in Hilliard's matching *Phoenix Portrait*.

Key dates

1558–1603



Phoenix Portrait, c.1575, attributed to Nicholas Hilliard



Artist Nicholas Hilliard (1547–1619), famed for his portraits of Elizabeth I

... that good Pelican that to
feed her people spareth not
to rend her own person

John **Lyly**

English writer, c.1553–1606, on Queen Elizabeth I